The world in brief

Catch up quickly on the global stories that matter

Photograph: Getty Images

Donald Trump set a ten-day timeline to reach a diplomatic breakthrough with **Iran** over its nuclear programme, warning that "bad things will happen" if a deal falls through. Government officials confirmed that America, which has been moving jets and warships into the Middle East, has enough military might in the region to launch an attack on Iran by this weekend.

Andrew Mountbatten-Windsor, formerly Prince Andrew, was released from police custody after being arrested on suspicion of misconduct in public office. The investigation, which remains open, follows the release of a vast email archive of Jeffrey Epstein, a dead sex offender whom Mr Mountbatten-Windsor was close to. In a statement King Charles III, his brother, said "the law must take its course." Mr Mountbatten-Windsor has denied wrongdoing.

Bill Gates withdrew plans to deliver a keynote speech at the AI Impact Summit in India, as scrutiny over his ties to Epstein grows. The Gates Foundation said the decision would keep the focus on the summit's "key priorities" just days after the philanthropic body pushed back against speculation that he would not attend. Mr Gates has denied any wrongdoing.

America's trade deficit widened by 33% to $70.3bn in December, fuelled by a surge in imports, despite Mr Trump's sweeping tariffs. Figures published by the Commerce Department showed that the full-year trade deficit was $901.5bn, 0.2% lower than in 2024. The drop was largely due to rising services exports. Trade in goods with China fell sharply, but imports from Vietnam, Mexico and India rose.

Peru swore in its ninth president in a decade, a day after his predecessor, José Jeri, was impeached and removed by Congress. José María Balcázar, a former judge and left-wing politician, will serve as interim president until general elections in April. Four of Peru's last eight presidents have been impeached and removed from office; two others resigned before the end of their terms.

Nestlé, the world's largest food firm, said it plans to sell its ice-cream business as part of a restructuring programme. The Swiss company, which appointed Philipp Navratil as its boss in September, also reported an 8.4% fall in full-year operating profits to SFr14.4bn ($18.6bn). It plans to prioritise its coffee, pet-care, nutrition and food and snacks brands.

America's Commission of Fine Arts unanimously approved Mr Trump's plan to build a 90,000 square foot **ballroom** where the **White House's** East Wing once stood. Little wonder: the panel consists entirely of Trump appointees. The project now has to clear another federal committee (which is also stuffed with his allies). It faces opposition from architects and a lawsuit from preservationists.

Figure of the day: 5–9%, the expected decline in China's car sales this year. Read the full story.

Photograph: Getty Images

America’s new pay-to-play diplomacy

Donald Trump will host the inaugural meeting of his “Board of Peace” in Washington, DC on Thursday. The United Nations has endorsed the board as the mechanism for ending the war in Gaza and overseeing its reconstruction. But Mr Trump’s ambitions seem more expansive: he claims a remit for the board “far beyond Gaza” and admits it may supplant the cash-starved UN.

Membership to the board, like a private club, is by invitation. Governments can buy permanent seats for $1bn and Mr Trump is chairman for life. American officials say those planning to attend on Thursday include Israel, Turkey, Gulf Arab monarchies and, more warily, India as well as several European and Asian allies. But many others have declined.

The board argues that it can “depart from approaches and institutions that have too often failed”; Mr Trump says he has raised $5bn for Gazans. The board’s success will not be measured by the show in Washington, but by what it achieves in Gaza.

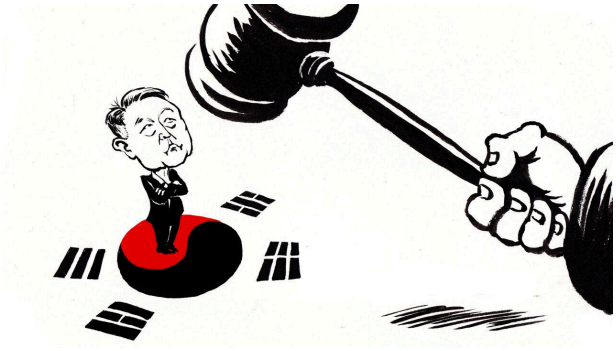


Illustration: David Simonds

Yoon Suk Yeol found guilty of leading an insurrection

In December 2024 Yoon Suk Yeol, then South Korea's president, declared martial law, accusing members of the National Assembly of exposing the country to "anti-state" forces. The legislature quickly ousted him. On Thursday judges found him guilty of leading an insurrection and sentenced him to life imprisonment. Prosecutors had sought the death penalty. He is expected to appeal.

Mr Yoon, who is 65, has already received a five-year prison sentence for blocking his arrest and is the defendant in seven other trials. The Democratic Party, which has a parliamentary majority, wants to pass an amendment that would prevent any government from pardoning him. Mr Yoon's People Power Party has yet to condemn his actions; another guilty verdict would plunge it further into crisis.

Photograph: EPA

The limits of India's AI dream

On Thursday Narendra Modi, India's prime minister, addressed politicians and tech executives gathered in Delhi for the fourth "AI Impact Summit"—and the first to be held in a developing country. Since the annual conference began in Britain in 2023 as a forum for earnest discussion of artificial intelligence's risks, it has morphed into something closer to a global trade fair.

Hoping to capture some of that buzz, India is casting itself as an emerging AI superpower. Such talk is mostly hot air: the country struggles to produce the advanced semiconductors AI needs and, despite a recent boom in data centres, lacks adequate computing power. Yet it has advantages: namely 900m internet users who spend an average of seven hours a day online, a huge source of data which can be used to train models. And Indian firms are adopting AI at a faster rate than the rest of the world. What it can definitely supply is demand.

Photograph: Getty Images

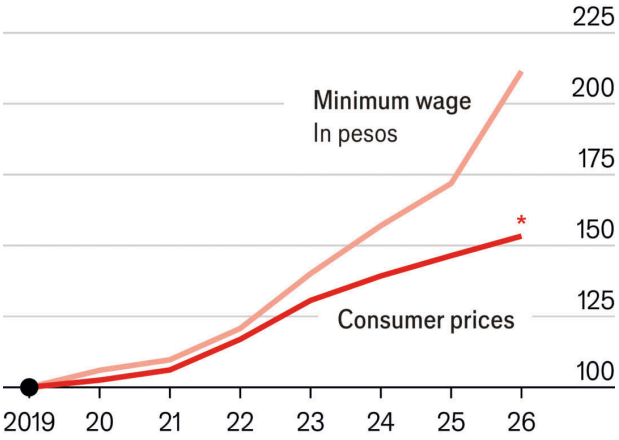
Rage over Colombia’s minimum wage

On Thursday Colombians will take to the streets in support of the new minimum wage. Last week, a court suspended a decree from Gustavo Petro, Colombia’s left-wing president, to raise the minimum wage by almost 24%. Workers have welcomed the increase. But critics argue that it will push up inflation and lead to job cuts. The court deemed it economically “unjustified”, and has given the government until Friday to suggest an alternative that complies with the law.

The clash is the latest between Mr Petro and Colombia’s institutions. When his tax reform bill was rejected by Congress last year he tried to impose tax increases by emergency decree; the courts suspended that, too. He has blamed these setbacks on an “institutional blockade”. Colombia holds primaries and legislative elections in March—and Mr Petro may be hoping that his fighting with the courts will distract voters from other problems, such as security, healthcare and corruption.

Peso-mism

Colombia, 2019=100



Sources: Bloomberg; Haver Analytics; IMF *Forecast

Photograph: Reuters

Can London Fashion Week reclaim its crown?

In the “Cool Britannia” era of the early 2000s, London was a fashion powerhouse. London Fashion Week, which starts on Thursday, was the highlight of the industry’s calendar, thanks to local designers like Stella McCartney and Alexander McQueen. But labels from Milan and Paris have since stolen much of that shine, and higher trade costs after Brexit have battered Britain’s fashion industry.

Laura Weir, the new head of the British Fashion Council, the trade body behind LFW, might change things. She has attracted new foreign buyers and press, and secured an extension of a government fund for emerging talent. And she has scrapped the five-figure fee to appear on the main runway, something that had priced out smaller designers. Ms Weir says she wants to lure back brands like McQueen—which showed its latest designs in Paris this year. The Fashion Council claims the industry contributed 3% of Britain’s GDP. With the right makeover, London’s runways could regain some of their swagger.

Illustration: Sandra Navarro

Daily quiz

We will serve you a new question each weekday. On Friday your challenge is to give us all five answers and tell us the theme. Email your responses (and your home city and country) by 1700 GMT on Friday to . We'll pick three winners at random and crown them on Saturday.

Thursday: Which Canadian business, originally founded in 1670 and noted for its department stores, was finally liquidated in 2025?

Wednesday: Which famous drummer was one of the founder members of the rock group Cream?

The one thing that doesn’t abide by majority rule is a person’s conscience.

Harper Lee